in the side and out of the side, but there are plenty of fine players around.

The Test series follows. India win comfortably in Johannesburg. We win comfortably in Durban. It's an excellent contest but, quietly, I am beginning to struggle. With scores of six and 17 while batting at No. 6 at the Wanderers, and then nine and 47 while opening at Kingsmead, everything feels a little up and down.

2007

Victory in the New Year Test at Newlands secures a 2–1 series win over India, but I manage to score only one in the first innings and 22 in the second. Nobody is saying too much but, as a batsman, you can never run away from the numbers after your name. My numbers are undeniably low and I'm worried.

There's no time to rest, reflect and recover and, barely a week later, we are playing the first Test against Pakistan at Centurion. Mohammad Asif, a fine fast bowler, is not helping my situation. He nips the ball around in both directions and, still opening, I am still struggling. In the first innings, I am dismissed by Asif for four. In the second innings, I am dismissed by Asif for 12 and, immediately after getting out, I head straight for the showers at SuperSport Park. There is no one else around. And nobody notices as, in despair, I stand under the water and cry – properly cry.

Pull yourself together, I tell myself, and I do; I dry off, go back to the changing room, and work hard to make sure that, even in poor form, I bring energy and enthusiasm to the group. It's not about me. It's about the team, and the only stat that matters is that we win the series 2–1.

That said, there is no respite for me. Even while the team is thriving, I manage only two and 15 in the second Test in Port Elizabeth, and, in the third Test at Newlands, I score just 11 and four.

This is beginning to feel like the most difficult period of my entire